



Rising through the ranks: Zion Suzuki's journey through Japan's youth ranks began long before his senior debut in 2022. Having represented every age group from U15 to U23, the goalkeeper was also part of Japan's squad at the FIFA U-17 World Cup in India in 2017. GETTY IMAGES

introduced Indian fans to a generation that is now reaching its peak. Nine years later, many of those teenagers, including Nakamura, Kubo, Aurelien Tchouameni (France), Eric García and Ferran Torres (Spain), have become the faces of their national teams, proving that football's youth tournaments are remembered for the careers they set in motion.

India was where many other World Cup stars first wore a FIFA badge. Now, in North America, they are fulfilling that early promise.

Aurelien Tchouameni has been the fulcrum of France's World Cup run. The Real Madrid midfielder has already racked up one assist in the competition and has completed 90 per cent of his attempted passes.

His positional awareness has allowed France to press higher without exposing its back line, and coach Didier Deschamps has built his midfield structure around the Real

Madrid man.

In India, he helped France complete a perfect group-stage campaign before a 2-1 defeat to Spain in the round of 16.

Ferran Torres was part of the Spain side that reached the final. He continues to play an important role in Spain's attack and has already featured for 126 minutes at this World Cup.

For England, Marc Guéhi has started two of its three group-stage matches as the Three Lions progressed to the knockout stage as group winners.

"It's a dream come true and the best moment of my life," Guehi had said after the title triumph in Kolkata. "I'm just really, really happy to have scored but it's all about the team performance."

Sergio Dest and Tim Weah, too, remain important cogs for the United States as it looks to make the most of a home World Cup.

Players from the 2017 FIFA U-17 World Cup in India now at the 2026 FIFA World Cup



Japan (5)

Keito Nakamura
Takefusa Kubo
Zion Suzuki
Yukinari Sugawara
Ayumu Seko

France (2)

Aurelien Tchouaméni
Maxence Lacroix

Spain (2)

Eric García
Ferran Torres

United States (2)

Sergino Dest
Tim Weah

New Zealand (2)

Elijah Just
Liberato Cacace

Turkey (1)

Yunus Akgün

Haiti (1)

Wilson Isidor

Algeria (1)

Amine Gouiri

England (1)

Marc Guéhi

Ivory Coast (1)

Seko Fofana